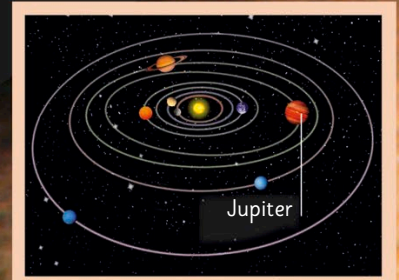


King of the planets

Jupiter, the solar system's largest planet, is a gas giant made up mainly of hydrogen. It is huge. If all the planets in the solar system were combined, Jupiter would still weigh more than twice as much.



Jupiter is the fifth planet from the Sun. More than 1,300 Earth-sized planets could fit into Jupiter.



The Great Red Spot reaches about 8 km (5 miles) above the surrounding clouds. Within it, winds reach a speed of 400 kph (250 mph).

The shrinking storm

The Great Red Spot is a storm that is almost the size of the Earth. Observed since 1666, its swirling mass takes about a week to turn anti-clockwise. Scientists have observed that the spot, which could once fit three Earths, is rapidly shrinking.

A thick cloud cover

Jupiter's cloudy atmosphere is about 1,000 km (600 miles) deep, but the clouds do not hide a solid crust. They swirl over an inner liquid layer of hydrogen and helium.

Jupiter's bands are caused by the movements and mixing of different gases in the atmosphere as the planet spins.